Policy & Strategy Lab

Course Concept Note

Stage 1 of 12 · Version 0.2 · Decisions 1 to 6 recorded · 10 November 2026

Item	Detail
Document	Course Concept Note (Course Bible, item 01)
Status	Draft. Decisions 1 to 6 are recorded in the decision log (DL-015 to DL-020); the other recommendations still await approval
Builds on	Decisions DL-001 to DL-020 in decision-log.md
Feeds	Stage 2: Learning Outcomes and Competency Framework

Changes in version 0.2

- Decision 5: no primary research. All evidence is published or publicly available. Sections 1, 7, 10.1, 10.5, 14, 15 and the Day 13 row in 16.2 updated.
- Decisions 1, 2 and 3 adopted provisionally on the designer's recommendation; to be reviewed at Stage 4.
- Decision 4 (completion standard) deferred to Stage 8. Decision 6 (capstone format) approved.

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Sections 1 to 13 describe the programme as it should stand once the recommendations are accepted. Sections 14 to 16 set out its risks, the assumptions it rests on and the changes we recommend. Section 17 audits the design as it stood before this note, and Section 18 lists what must be decided before Stage 2. Where this note departs from the draft curriculum developed so far, it says so and gives the reason.

Summary

The central idea is sound and, as far as we can tell, uncommon: teach the discipline of consulting-style problem-solving, and apply it to Indian public problems with the institutional and political seriousness that policy analysis requires. Each participant carries one self-selected case through the full cycle, from a vague concern to a defended recommendation, while learning alongside a cohort that shares one method.

The draft curriculum has five weaknesses that should be fixed before learning outcomes are written.

1. **It is too dense.** Nineteen teaching days name roughly seventy frameworks and methods, plus some forty further concepts. At 45 minutes of instruction and demonstration a day, that leaves about twelve minutes per framework. Participants would recognise many tools and be able to use few.
2. **It is hypothesis-driven in name but not in sequence.** Hypotheses arrive on Day 9, after a week of decomposition and a week of contextual analysis. The method the course claims to teach puts an early working answer near the start.
3. **It uses the wrong tools for one step.** Day 8 prioritises which issues to investigate using tools built to rank interventions (ICE, Impact-Effort). Those belong in Week 4.
4. **It has no client.** Nothing requires a participant to name who the analysis is for or what decision that person faces. Without a decision, problem definition drifts, options appraisal has no criteria and the final presentation has no audience.
5. **Its logistics have not been tested against arithmetic.** Case approval on Day 5 means a rejected case costs a week. Final presentations for a cohort larger than about nine do not fit into a two-hour Day 20. Detailed feedback on every workbook for twenty participants is about eighty hours of grading.

Section 16 sets out fourteen changes. The most important are: one anchor tool per day; an early, sealed working hypothesis; a named client and decision for every case; case selection before Day 1; three India-specific reality tests (jurisdiction, money and frontline delivery); Moore's strategic triangle as the final test of any recommendation; and a cap of sixteen participants for a single instructor.

Six decisions were needed before Stage 2. Their outcomes are recorded in Section 18.1 and in the decision log.

1. Programme title and positioning

Recommended title: Policy & Strategy Lab

Descriptor: A 20-day intensive in structured problem-solving for Indian public policy

"Lab" is the right word only if every session produces work. The design below meets that test, so the word is earned rather than decorative. Three alternatives were considered and set aside.

Alternative	Why not
Consulting Problem-Solving Bootcamp	Signals case-interview preparation and job placement. Undersells the policy and institutional content, which is where this programme differs from what is already available.
Public Policy Consulting Academy	Implies an institution, a faculty and a career pipeline that a first cohort cannot yet claim.
The Policy Analyst Programme	Accurate but generic. Loses the strategy and execution half of the identity.

The current line, "Think like a consultant. Analyse like a researcher. Solve like a policy strategist", is serviceable. A variant worth considering is "Think like a consultant. Investigate like a researcher. Decide like a public servant." Its last clause carries the programme's central claim: public decisions are made under constraints of legitimacy, jurisdiction and capacity that a firm does not face. This is a minor choice and can wait until Stage 12.

Positioning statement

For students and early-career professionals who want to work on public problems in India, the Policy & Strategy Lab is a four-week, practice-based programme in which each participant takes one real policy problem from a vague concern to a defended, implementable recommendation. Unlike academic policy courses, it ends in a decision and an implementation plan rather than an essay. Unlike consulting bootcamps, it treats the state as a set of institutions with divided jurisdiction, contested goals and frontline discretion, not as a firm with a single objective.

What the programme is not

- Not case-interview preparation, although graduates should find case interviews easier.
- Not a survey of public policy theory. Theory appears where it changes how a participant analyses their own case.
- Not a research methods course. It teaches enough method to support a defensible diagnosis, not enough to publish.
- Not a fieldwork course. All evidence comes from published and publicly available sources.
- Not training in any one firm's proprietary method. It draws on several and attributes each.

The promise, calibrated

Four weeks can produce a capable junior analyst on a scoped problem: someone who can be handed an unfamiliar issue on Monday and return by Friday with a structured diagnosis, a clear account of what the evidence does and does not show, and a recommendation that names who must act. Four weeks cannot produce a consultant, a researcher or a sector expert. The marketing, the certificate and the opening session should promise the first and should not imply the others.

2. Rationale and the educational problem

The programme responds to three gaps.

The description-to-decision gap. Social science training in India largely rewards description and critique: the essay, the literature review, the examination answer. Policy work asks for something different, a recommendation made under uncertainty for someone who has to act. A student can write a competent essay on why foundational learning outcomes are poor and still be unable to say what a district education officer should do differently next term, at what cost, and how anyone would know whether it worked. What is missing is not subject knowledge. It is the ability to turn knowledge into a structured judgement for a decision-maker.

The consulting-transfer gap. Consulting methods teach structure well. Issue trees, hypothesis-driven work and top-down communication are learnable and useful. But consulting training, and case-interview preparation in particular, tends to treat the client as a firm with one objective, a single decision-maker and a budget that follows the analysis. Public problems rarely look like that. Goals are contested. Jurisdiction is divided between the Union, the states and local bodies. Budgets are fixed in advance and tied to scheme guidelines. The people who determine outcomes are often frontline workers with heavy caseloads and wide discretion. A participant who applies consulting tools without this knowledge produces analysis that is tidy and wrong.

The implementation gap. Indian policy discussion often stops at design. Much of the literature on Indian state capacity locates failure further down the chain: in Pritchett's description of a "flailing state" whose capable centre cannot reliably direct its own field agencies; in Kapur's account of a state whose performance ranges from impressive management of complex tasks at enormous scale to inadequate provision of core public goods; and in Muralidharan's argument that weak state capacity, more than a shortage of ideas or money, is the binding constraint on India's development. A recommendation that ignores the delivery chain is not finished.

The skills that close these gaps are usually picked up on the job, unevenly, rather than taught. The Lab teaches them directly by making each participant complete the full cycle once, on a real problem, with structured feedback at four points. We treat the premise that these skills are under-taught as an assumption to be tested through the entry diagnostic and the pilot (Section 15), not as an established fact.

Why twenty days. A full cycle from problem definition to defended recommendation needs about this long if participants are to revise their work in response to feedback, which is where most of the learning happens. A shorter programme forces them to skip either the evidence or the revision. A longer one loses participants who are studying or working alongside it. The constraint has a useful side effect: it forces tight scoping, which is itself one of the skills being taught.

3. Intended audience and assumed prior knowledge

Primary audience

- Final-year undergraduates and postgraduates in economics, political science, sociology, public policy, public administration, development studies, law and related fields.
- Early-career professionals, with up to about three years of experience, moving towards roles in government programme management units, state fellowship programmes, think tanks, foundations, CSR teams and development consulting.

Secondary audience

- Doctoral students and research fellows who want applied analytical skills alongside their academic training.
- Mid-career professionals from other sectors. They bring context and need method, which changes the pitch of a session. A few in a cohort enrich discussion; a cohort dominated by them would need a different programme.

Prior knowledge

Area	Assumed	Not assumed	How the gap is handled
Reading	Can read a government report and an academic article in English	Fast reading of long documents	Guided reading questions; extracts rather than whole reports

Area	Assumed	Not assumed	How the gap is handled
Writing	Can write clear paragraphs in English	Memo and executive-summary writing	Taught on Day 15 and practised throughout
Numbers	Percentages, ratios, averages	Statistical inference, regression	Day 12 teaches descriptive analysis only; no inferential statistics are required
Spreadsheets	Data entry, simple formulas	Sorting, filtering, pivot tables, charts	Pre-course primer of 60 to 90 minutes
Indian government	General awareness	Seventh Schedule, 73rd and 74th Amendments, budget documents, centrally sponsored schemes	Taught on Day 6
Consulting methods	Nothing	Everything	The programme
Policy theory	Nothing	Everything	Short readings attached to specific days

Entry diagnostic. Before Day 1, each participant completes a short task at home: read a two-page case brief, write a problem statement of no more than 150 words, list the five questions they would need answered, and suggest one thing the responsible official should do. The task is scored against four criteria on a simple scale. A parallel task using a different case is set in the final week. The comparison gives each participant evidence of their own progress, gives the Analyst Development Tracker a baseline, and gives the programme its first real measure of whether it works. If the programme is oversubscribed, the diagnostic and a short statement of a candidate problem can double as the selection mechanism.

4. Programme philosophy

Seven principles govern design decisions. When a later choice is contested, they are the reference point.

1. Frameworks are instruments of reasoning. A tool is taught through the question it answers, the inputs it needs, the output it produces and the ways it is misused. A participant who can draw an issue tree but cannot say what it is for has not learned it. Every tool taught in depth is documented on a one-page tool card in that format (Section 6.3).

2. One problem, carried all the way. Each participant works on a single case for twenty days. Every workbook builds part of the final report, and nothing is done once and thrown away. This is what makes a finished product possible in four weeks and what makes feedback cumulative.

3. An early answer, tested hard. Participants commit to a working answer on Day 3 and spend the rest of the programme trying to break it. They record what changed and why. Changing one's mind in response to evidence is assessed as a strength.

4. Decisions, not descriptions. Every case has a named decision-maker and a decision that person faces. Analysis that does not bear on the decision is cut. This single requirement does more than any framework to keep the work focused.

5. The state is not a firm. Every recommendation is tested against who has the legal authority to act, where the money comes from and what frontline workers will actually do. Consulting tools are used with that discipline or not at all.

6. Make, then challenge, then revise. Every session produces an artefact. Every week includes structured challenge from peers. Revision in response to challenge is expected and credited.

7. Distribution is an analytical test, not a closing paragraph. Who benefits, who pays, who is excluded and who was not consulted are questions asked at fixed points: in problem definition, stakeholder mapping, data disaggregation and options appraisal. Each has its own row in the relevant template.

5. Intellectual foundations

Theory enters the Lab in one way only: as a question asked of the participant's own case. Each thinker below is attached to a specific day, introduced in five to ten minutes, supported by a short reading (an article or a chapter, not a book) and carried into one workbook question. There are no stand-alone theory lectures. Across the programme this comes to about a dozen readings, which is a number participants can actually complete.

Day	Thinker and work	Central idea	The question it puts to the participant's case
1	Rittel and Webber, "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning" (1973)	Many public problems are "wicked": no definitive formulation, no stopping rule, no single right answer	Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?
2	Sen, *Development as Freedom* (1999)	Wellbeing lies in what people are able to do and be, not only in what they have	Are you measuring access to a resource, or what people can actually do with it?
5	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, *Building State Capability* (2017)	Problem construction; capability traps; isomorphic mimicry	Would the obvious fix copy the form of a programme that worked elsewhere without the capability behind it?
6	Pritchett, "Is India a Flailing State?" (2009); Kapur, "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" (2020)	A capable centre with unreliable field delivery; uneven state performance across tasks	At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action on the ground?
7	Ostrom, *Governing the Commons* (1990)	Rules-in-use differ from rules on paper; communities can build institutions for collective action	Which rules actually govern behaviour here?
7, 18	Lipsky, *Street-Level Bureaucracy* (1980)	Frontline workers make policy through discretion exercised under pressure	What will the person delivering this actually do, given their caseload and incentives?
8	Simon, *Administrative Behavior* (1947)	Bounded rationality; satisficing	Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?
15, 17	Rumelt, *Good Strategy/Bad Strategy* (2011)	A strategy has a kernel: a diagnosis, a guiding policy and coherent actions	Does your recommendation contain all three, or is it a list of goals?
16	Hall, "Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State" (1993)	First-, second- and third-order change	Are you adjusting settings, changing instruments or changing goals?
17	Lindblom, "The Science of 'Muddling Through'" (1959)	Incremental comparison often beats comprehensive analysis	Is a comprehensive solution realistic here, or would a sequence of small, reversible steps be wiser?
17	Moore, *Creating Public Value* (1995)	The strategic triangle: public value, legitimacy and support, operational capacity	Does the option pass all three tests, or only one?
17, 18	Flyvbjerg and Gardner, *How Big Things Get Done* (2023)	Optimism bias; reference-class forecasting	What actually happened to the cost and timeline of similar efforts?

Day	Thinker and work	Central idea	The question it puts to the participant's case
18	Weiss, on theory-based evaluation (1995)	A programme's causal assumptions should be made explicit so that they can be tested	Which links in your theory of change are assumptions, and how would you know if one failed?
19	Kingdon, *Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies* (1984)	Problem, policy and politics streams; policy windows	Is there a window for this recommendation, and which stream is missing?

Indian scholarship should carry a substantial share of the reading rather than serving as illustration for theories developed elsewhere. Candidates for Stage 10 include Kapur (2020), Pritchett (2009), Muralidharan (2024) and Mangla (2022) on bureaucratic norms and education delivery in rural India.

Three ideas run through the whole programme without belonging to a single day: state capacity, the gap between policy on paper and policy in practice, and the political feasibility of technically sound options. The table is the mechanism for making sure they are taught rather than mentioned.

6. Consulting and strategy methodology

6.1 The spine: the seven-step process

The programme is organised around the seven-step problem-solving process associated with McKinsey and set out in detail by two of its alumni, Charles Conn and Robert McLean, in *Bulletproof Problem Solving* (2018). The steps are not taught as a list. Each is taught as the answer to a question, together with the change that public policy demands.

Step	The question it answers	What changes in public policy	Week
1. Define the problem	What decision, for whom, and what would success look like?	Definitions are contested; affected groups may disagree with the decision-maker; success may be a capability rather than a number	1
2. Disaggregate	What are the component questions?	Trees must include institutional, legal and political branches, not only technical ones	1
3. Prioritise	Which branches matter most and can be influenced?	"Ability to influence" depends on who holds jurisdiction and what is politically feasible	2
4. Build a workplan	What analysis, from which source, by when?	Data availability, especially below state level, is often the binding constraint	2
5. Conduct analyses	What does the evidence show?	Administrative data must be read critically; triangulation is essential	3
6. Synthesise	So what?	Facts, inferences and assumptions must be kept visibly apart	3
7. Communicate	What should the decision-maker do, and why?	Options, criteria, trade-offs, implementation and legitimacy all need explicit treatment	4

Set beside Bardach and Patashnik's eightfold path for policy analysis (define the problem, assemble some evidence, construct the alternatives, select the criteria, project the outcomes, confront the trade-offs, decide, tell your story), the two methods turn out to divide the labour between them. Six of the seven steps build the diagnosis and the seventh communicates the answer. The eightfold path spends two steps on definition and evidence and six on constructing alternatives, choosing between them and explaining the choice. Consulting method is strongest at diagnosis. Policy analysis is strongest at choice under contested criteria.

The Lab therefore uses the seven steps to govern Weeks 1 to 3, and the eightfold path, together with Moore's strategic triangle, to govern Week 4. This is the clearest practical expression of the programme's dual identity, and it should be shown to participants on Day 1.

6.2 What each tradition contributes

Attribution matters for honesty and, if the materials are ever sold, for intellectual property. This note uses four categories.

- **Originated:** created and published by the organisation or its staff.
- **Developed:** substantially developed by the organisation's staff or alumni, with earlier roots.
- **Popularised:** made widely known by the organisation, which did not originate it.
- **Uses:** the organisation uses or describes it; no claim of origin.

Source	What the Lab borrows	Attribution	Where
McKinsey & Company	Seven-step process; issue and logic trees; hypothesis-driven working	Developed (documented by Conn and McLean)	Weeks 1 to 3
Barbara Minto, at McKinsey	Pyramid Principle; Situation, Complication, Question, Answer (SCQA)	Originated by Minto	Day 15
Boston Consulting Group	Strategy Palette: classical, adaptive, visionary, shaping and renewal approaches	Originated (Reeves, Haanæs and Sinha 2015)	Day 18
Bain & Company	RAPID decision roles: Recommend, Agree, Perform, Input, Decide	Originated (Rogers and Blenko 2006); a registered trademark of Bain	Day 18
IDEO and the Stanford d.school	Human-centred design; the desirability, feasibility and viability lens; How Might We questions	Developed and popularised; How Might We has earlier origins	Day 16
The Bridgespan Group	Intended impact paired with theory of change	Developed (Colby, Stone and Carttar 2004); theory of change itself is older (Weiss 1995)	Day 18
Deloitte	Government transformation sequence (strategy, design, build, deliver, innovate); operating model design	Uses and describes (Deloitte US website); stage content not yet reviewed	Day 18, reference only
PwC, KPMG, Accenture	Nothing attributed yet	Stage 3 research item	To be decided
Public sector and development practice	Bardach and Patashnik's eightfold path; Moore's strategic triangle; HM Treasury Green Book options appraisal and Five Case Model; delivery chain analysis; problem-driven political economy analysis; problem-driven iterative adaptation (PDIA)	Originated by the named authors and institutions	Days 1, 6, 7, 17 and 18

Two observations follow. First, the public sector methods in the last row are more directly useful for this programme than several of the consultancy frameworks, and they deserve teaching time on merit rather than as an afterthought. Second, MECE is a general structuring principle associated with Minto and consulting practice rather than a framework with an owner, and SWOT has contested origins. Neither should be attributed to a single source on a slide.

Intellectual property. Teaching a framework with attribution is ordinary academic practice. Reproducing a firm's copyrighted diagrams or materials in handouts, especially if the programme is sold, is a different matter. The working rule: name and cite every framework, redraw every diagram in the Lab's own visual system, describe RAPID as a registered trademark of Bain & Company, and take advice before a commercial launch if any material is reproduced rather than paraphrased.

6.3 The tool card standard

Every tool taught in depth is documented on a single page with the same eight fields:

1. The question it answers.
2. The inputs it needs.
3. The output it produces.
4. The steps.
5. One worked Indian example.
6. Common misuses.
7. What it cannot tell you.
8. Where it sits in the seven steps.

Participants finish with about twenty cards, which become the toolkit they keep. The cards also discipline the course designers: a tool whose card cannot be completed honestly has no place in the Lab.

7. Intended learning outcomes

By the end of the programme, a participant who meets the completion standard will be able to:

1. **Frame.** Convert a broad public concern into a decision-focused problem statement that names the affected population, place, responsible institution, decision-maker, decision and measure of success.
2. **Structure.** Build a mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive issue or hypothesis tree to three levels, and use it to decide what to analyse and what to leave out.
3. **Diagnose.** Distinguish symptoms, proximate causes and structural causes, and represent at least one feedback relationship that sustains the problem.
4. **Situate.** Map the jurisdiction, money, delivery chain and actors that shape the problem, including those with an interest but no voice.
5. **Hypothesise.** State falsifiable hypotheses, specify what evidence would weaken each one, and keep a register of how each fares.
6. **Investigate.** Locate, assess and triangulate published Indian administrative, survey, audit and research evidence, recording an explicit reliability judgement for each source used.
7. **Synthesise.** Reduce findings to a governing message using the Pyramid Principle, keeping facts, inferences and assumptions visibly separate.
8. **Decide.** Generate at least three genuinely distinct options and appraise them against explicit criteria, including distributional effects and feasibility, to reach a justified recommendation.
9. **Plan delivery.** Specify a theory of change, decision rights, responsibilities, risks and indicators for the recommended option.
10. **Communicate and defend.** Present the recommendation to a decision-making panel and respond to challenge without overstating the evidence.

These are programme-level outcomes. Stage 2 will add observable performance indicators for each one, map them to days and workbooks, and check that the assessment tests every outcome.

8. Competency architecture

The ten competency domains in the master brief map onto the outcomes as follows.

Domain	Outcomes	Taught mainly on	Principal evidence
A. Problem framing	1	Days 1 and 2	Problem Definition Canvas; Gate 1
B. Problem structuring	2	Days 3 and 8	Issue tree and pruning rationale
C. Causal and systems analysis	3	Days 4 and 5	Problem tree; causal loop diagram
D. Strategic and institutional analysis	4	Days 6 and 7	Delivery chain map; stakeholder and incentive matrix
E. Research and evidence	6	Days 10 to 13	Evidence register; Gate 2
F. Hypothesis-driven analysis	5	Days 3, 9 and 14	Sealed working answer; hypothesis register; testing matrix
G. Policy design and appraisal	8	Days 16 and 17	Options appraisal
H. Strategy execution	9	Days 18 and 19	Theory of change; responsibility matrix; risk register; indicator framework
I. Professional communication	7, 10	Days 15, 19 and 20	Diagnostic memo (Gate 3); deck; defence
J. Professional judgement	All	Days 14, 17 and 20	Analyst's Ledger; reflection; defence

Each domain is assessed on a three-level scale.

Level	Description
Foundational	Applies the tool correctly with a template and prompting. The output is complete but generic, and its limitations go unnoticed.
Working	Applies the tool independently to the participant's own case, justifies the choices made and names the main limitations. **This is the completion standard.**
Advanced	Selects and adapts tools to the problem, anticipates objections, integrates evidence across methods and changes course when the evidence requires it.

Setting the Working level as the completion standard keeps the certificate honest. A participant who attends every session but cannot apply the tools independently has not met it.

9. Teaching model

9.1 The daily session

The agreed two-hour structure stays as the default.

Minutes	Activity
0 to 10	Opening problem or retrieval question
10 to 35	Concept
35 to 55	Demonstration on the spine case
55 to 90	Group activity
90 to 110	Individual workbook application to own case
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task

Three variants are needed.

- **Gate days (5, 10 and 15).** The concept block shrinks to ten minutes, and 40 minutes go to pod peer review of the gate submission against the rubric.
- **Studio days (11 to 13).** Short instruction, then supervised working time with the instructor circulating. Research cannot be taught well from slides.
- **Day 20.** Presentations and defence throughout (Section 12).

9.2 The weekly rhythm

Days	Purpose
Monday to Wednesday	Learn and apply
Thursday	Challenge: a simulation, a hypothesis battle or a red team
Friday	Consolidate: gate submission, pod review, scope check

Thursdays (Days 4, 9, 14 and 19) carry the major simulations from the activity bank. Fridays carry the gates.

9.3 Consulting pods

Participants work in pods of four, and each member owns a different case. Four roles rotate weekly.

- **Chair:** keeps time and makes sure every case gets attention.
- **Sceptic:** must challenge at least one claim in every case at every pod session.
- **Evidence checker:** asks "how do you know?" and checks one source per case.
- **Scribe:** records the challenges and responses in the pod log.

The sceptic and evidence-checker roles turn red-teaming from an occasional event into a habit. The pod log is the evidence base for the peer review component of the assessment.

How pods are composed is still open (Decision 10). One option deserves attention: pods whose members work on different problems in the same state or city. They can share the contextual work of Week 2, covering the state's institutions, budget and politics, and spend their individual time on problem-specific analysis. Collaboration then becomes real rather than procedural, and the final pod presentation has a natural common thread.

9.4 The spine case

The instructor demonstrates every anchor tool on a single running case, chosen and fully developed before the programme starts. Participants watch one complete project move from vague concern to defended recommendation, one tool at a time. Group activities use other cases for variety, but demonstrations always return to the spine. The finished spine case also becomes the exemplar portfolio that participants can consult.

This is the most efficient way to show how the tools connect to one another, which is what participants find hardest to learn from framework-by-framework teaching. Criteria and candidates are in Section 10.4.

9.5 Participant workload

Element	Hours
Pre-course: diagnostic, case shortlist, spreadsheet primer	3 to 4
Live sessions, 20 x 2 hours	40
Independent work, averaging 45 minutes on 19 days	about 14

Element	Hours
Final report after Day 20	6 to 8
Total	**about 63 to 66**

During the four weeks this is roughly 13 to 14 hours a week. That suits students and is demanding for people in full-time work. Publicity material should say so plainly.

9.6 Instructor workload

Feedback is where programmes of this kind usually fail, so it has been estimated before anything else is built. Assume four gates with detailed feedback at about 35 minutes per participant each, six lighter workbook checks at about 10 minutes each, and 45 minutes for the final report. That is about four hours per participant.

Cohort	Feedback and grading hours	Per working day, over five weeks
12	about 49	about 2.0
16	about 65	about 2.6
20	about 82	about 3.3
24	about 98	about 3.9

These hours come on top of two hours of teaching and the daily preparation. A single instructor can sustain a cohort of about sixteen. Beyond that the programme needs a teaching assistant, or the gates need lighter feedback, which would weaken the programme's main strength. The estimates should be tested in the pilot.

9.7 Delivery mode

Whether sessions run online, in person or in hybrid form has not been decided. It changes activity design substantially: negotiations and red teams work differently on a video call, whiteboarding needs a shared tool, and pod sessions need breakout rooms. This needs settling before Stage 7 (Decision 8).

10. Indian policy application

10.1 Case selection

A participant who chooses "poverty in India" has chosen a field of study, not a problem. Case selection is therefore a process with checkpoints, and it begins before Day 1 so that a rejected case does not cost a week.

When	What happens
Seven days before Day 1	Participant submits three candidate problems, one paragraph each
Three days before Day 1	Instructor returns brief comments and flags any that will not work
Day 2	Case Approval Form submitted; provisional approval
Day 5 (Gate 1)	Scope lock. After this the case can be narrowed but not changed

Narrowing follows a ladder: domain, issue, problem, population, place, institution, decision. Two examples:

Rung	Example A	Example B
Domain	Urban governance	Education
Issue	Solid waste management	Foundational learning
Problem	Low compliance with household source segregation	Low reading levels at the end of Grade 3
Population	Households in residential wards	Children in government primary schools
Place	One named municipal corporation	One named district
Institution	The corporation's solid waste department	The state school education department and the district office
Decision	Which of three compliance strategies the Commissioner should fund next financial year	What the District Education Officer should change in teacher support next academic year

The **Case Approval Form** asks for: the problem statement; the population, place and institution; the named decision-maker and the decision; why the problem matters; at least two public data sources that the participant has already opened and checked, and one published qualitative or field-based source; any ethical or access concerns; and three candidate questions.

The **feasibility rubric** scores nine criteria from 0 to 2: specificity, public significance, evidence availability, research accessibility within four weeks, institutional clarity (someone has the authority to act), analytical complexity (enough to need the method, not so much that it overwhelms it), actionability, scope, and ethical safety (2 means low risk). A case needs at least 12 of 18, with no zero on evidence availability, institutional clarity or ethical safety.

10.2 Three reality tests

Every case and every recommendation must pass three India-specific tests. They are taught on Day 6 and applied again on Day 17.

Jurisdiction: who has the authority to act? Participants need a working knowledge of the Union, State and Concurrent Lists in the Seventh Schedule; of the 73rd and 74th Amendments and the functions listed for panchayats and municipalities in the Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules; and of the difference between legislative authority, administrative control and the influence that comes with funding. A recommendation addressed to an authority that cannot act on it fails this test.

Money: where does the funding come from? Participants need to read a budget line, distinguish central sector schemes from centrally sponsored schemes, understand cost-sharing between the Union and the states, recognise the role of Finance Commission transfers and understand why the own revenues of urban local bodies matter. Each participant traces the money for their own case in a short "follow the money" exercise, using budget documents and analyses from sources such as PRS Legislative Research and Open Budgets India.

Frontline: what will the people who deliver it actually do? The delivery chain from ministry to state department, district, block and frontline worker is mapped for each case. Lipsky's question is asked at the last link: given caseload, discretion and incentives, what happens when this reaches the person who has to implement it?

These tests are the most concrete expression of the fifth principle. They address the consulting-transfer gap more directly than any amount of theory.

10.3 The Indian evidence base

Day 11 introduces the main sources, with explicit attention to what each can and cannot support: the National Family Health Survey, the Periodic Labour Force Survey, the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey, UDISE+, the National Achievement Survey, the Annual Status of Education Report, NCRB publications, census tables, scheme MIS dashboards, CAG audit reports, parliamentary standing committee reports, PRS Legislative Research, the data.gov.in portal and NITI Aayog's National Data and Analytics Platform.

Two cautions apply. The first is vintage: several major datasets are between rounds or several years old, and every chart must state its reference year. The second is granularity: much survey data is representative only at state level, so a district-level case may have to rely on administrative data, which has its own reporting problems. Both are checked at case approval rather than discovered on Day 12. The current round and coverage of each source will be verified in Stage 10.

10.4 Classroom cases

Two kinds of common case are needed.

The spine case is used in every demonstration. It should have rich public data, involve at least two levels of government, depend visibly on frontline workers, carry a clear distributional dimension and be analysable without taking a partisan position. Two candidates fit well.

- **Household source segregation of solid waste in a named city.** Municipal jurisdiction under the 74th Amendment, the role of sanitation workers and informal waste pickers, behaviour change, user charges and published city rankings make it rich at every stage.
- **Foundational literacy in government primary schools in a named district.** It has strong public data, a long research literature, teachers as street-level bureaucrats and an active national mission. Its drawback is that many participants are likely to choose it for their own cases.

The activity bank of six to eight shorter cases is used in group exercises. The draft list (welfare scheme access, MGNREGA implementation, women's workforce participation, public healthcare delivery, air pollution, digital exclusion, urban transport and agricultural market access) is a good starting point. Each needs a two-page teaching brief, written in Stage 7 and fact-checked in Stage 10. Briefs should use real institutions and verified data, or be clearly labelled as stylised.

10.5 Working norms for sensitive cases

Indian policy problems are often politically charged. Five norms protect participants and the programme.

1. Analyse institutions and incentives, not individuals. No participant attributes a failure to a named official.
2. Remain non-partisan. Party positions are data about political feasibility, not targets.
3. Hold criticism to the same evidence standard as any other claim.
4. Collect no primary data. The programme uses published and publicly available evidence only (Decision 5), so no participant interviews, surveys or observes anyone for their case.
5. Where a matter is before a court, analyse the policy questions it raises without offering a view on the merits of the case.

11. Assessment philosophy

Four principles shape the assessment.

1. **Assess thinking through artefacts.** Every mark attaches to something the participant produced.
2. **Keep individual and group performance separate.** No participant's individual marks rise or fall with their pod.
3. **Reward revision.** A participant who responds well to feedback should outscore one who submitted once and stopped.
4. **Use one set of criteria everywhere.** Every rubric uses the same four dimensions, so that feedback in Week 1 is directly useful in Week 4: conceptual understanding, analytical reasoning, evidence, and professional communication.

The provisional weights agreed earlier can stay. What needs changing is the definition of one component. "Research and evidence quality" is a property of all the work rather than a separate piece of work, so as written it would be assessed twice, once within the workbooks and once on its own. The fix is to attach it to a distinct artefact, the evidence register, which each participant maintains from Day 10.

Component	Weight	What is assessed	When
Workbook portfolio	35%	Ten workbooks, assessed as a portfolio with credit for documented revision	Gates on Days 5, 10 and 15; portfolio after Day 20
Evidence register	15%	Source quality, reliability judgements, triangulation, accurate citation	Opened on Day 10; assessed with the report
Pod contribution and peer review	10%	Pod log, quality of written peer reviews, structured peer assessment	Weekly
Final individual report	20%	The client report	72 hours after Day 20
Presentation and defence	20%	Individual presentation and defence 15%; pod synthesis 5%	Day 20

Two mechanics are possible (Decision 12). In the first, gates are formative: they receive detailed feedback but no marks, and the portfolio is marked once at the end, including a short revision note for each gate that shows what changed and why. In the second, each gate is marked on submission. We recommend the first. It rewards revision directly, removes the pressure to be right first time and saves instructor time, because gate feedback does not have to be calibrated against marks.

Feedback format. Every gate receives feedback under five headings: strongest element, critical weakness, missing dimension, required revision, and next analytical task. Recurring patterns are logged in each participant's Analyst Development Tracker, for example: jumps to solutions, treats correlation as causation, relies on a single source, overstates certainty.

Completion and distinction. A certificate of completion requires attendance at a stated minimum, all four gates submitted, the report, the defence, and the Working level in every competency domain. A distinction requires the Advanced level in a stated number of domains. The thresholds are Decision 4.

12. Final capstone concept

The capstone is the case, finished. It has five parts.

Part	Form	Notes
Client report	3,500 to 4,500 words, plus annexes	Written to the named decision-maker. Annexes hold the issue tree, evidence register, options appraisal, implementation plan and indicator framework
Full deck	10 to 12 slides	Submitted, not presented in full. Follows the consulting narrative agreed earlier
Presentation	5 slides, 6 minutes	The recommendation, the diagnosis behind it, the evidence, the choice and the delivery plan
Defence	6 minutes of questions	Individual. Questions drawn from the defence bank and from the participant's own weak points
Reflection	500 words	Opens the sealed Day 3 answer and explains what changed, what did not and why

The word limit for the report is deliberately modest. Most of the content already exists in the workbooks; the task is to select, sequence and argue. Length is not rewarded.

Timeline. The draft deck is due on Day 19 (Gate 4). Presentations take place on Day 20. The report is due 72 hours later, so that participants can respond to the panel's challenge. Asking for the report on Day 20 itself would reward last-minute writing and waste the most useful feedback of the programme.

The pod's collective component. Each pod adds one shared slide, presented jointly, on what its cases reveal together: about the method, about the institutions involved or about where delivery tends to fail. If pod members share a state, this slide almost writes itself; if not, it is a genuine synthesis exercise. It carries the 5 per cent pod synthesis mark.

The arithmetic of Day 20. At 12 minutes per participant plus a minute of changeover, a two-hour session holds about nine presentations. Allow a further three minutes or so for each pod's synthesis slide.

Cohort	Presentation time needed	Options
8 or 9	about 2 hours	Day 20 as planned
12	about 2.6 hours	Extend Day 20, or also use the second hour of Day 19
16	about 3.5 hours	Two parallel panels, or an extended Day 20
20	about 4.3 hours	Two parallel panels, which need a second panel chair

This is a hard constraint, not a detail, and it is one reason this note recommends a cohort of no more than sixteen for the first run.

Defence questions will be drawn from a bank organised by competency domain: why this problem; how it was defined; why this method; what evidence supports the diagnosis and what contradicts it; which assumptions remain untested; which rival explanation is strongest; who might oppose the recommendation; what would make implementation fail; what would change the recommendation; and how success would be measured. The full bank is a Stage 11 deliverable.

13. Distinctive features

Eight features distinguish the Lab from the courses a prospective participant might compare it with.

1. **A client for every case.** Each analysis is written for a named decision-maker facing a stated decision. This borrows from client-based policy capstones such as the Policy Analysis Exercise at the Harvard Kennedy School, adapted so that the client is identified rather than formally engaged.

2. **One method, many problems.** Pods hold different cases, so every participant sees the same tools applied to several problems. The programme trains transfer, not memorisation of one worked example.
3. **The spine case.** One fully worked project is modelled from start to finish across the twenty days.
4. **The Analyst's Ledger.** Every substantive claim in every workbook is tagged as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis. It is a small habit that makes analytical humility visible and assessable.
5. **The sealed answer.** On Day 3 each participant writes down their best current answer and seals it. They open it in the final reflection and account for what changed.
6. **Built-in challenge.** Sceptic and evidence-checker roles in every pod, a red team on Day 14 and a panel on Day 20 make critique routine rather than personal.
7. **Three reality tests.** Jurisdiction, money and frontline delivery are applied to every case. They are the programme's answer to the consulting-transfer gap.
8. **Tool cards.** Each participant leaves with about twenty one-page cards documenting each tool's purpose, inputs, outputs, misuses and limits.

14. Risks and limitations

Risk	Consequence	Mitigation
Framework overload	Participants recognise many tools and can use few	One anchor tool per day; supporting tools demonstrated only; the rest in a reference library
Unworkable cases	Participants lose days to topics without data or without anyone able to act	Pre-course shortlist; data sources checked at approval; scope lock at Gate 1
Uneven preparation	Weaker participants fall behind on spreadsheets or writing; stronger ones are bored	Entry diagnostic; spreadsheet primer; extension tasks on tool cards
Instructor overload	Feedback becomes thin or late, removing the programme's main value	Cohort cap; formative gates; common rubric; teaching assistant above sixteen participants
Free-riding in pods	Group marks reward the wrong people	Individual cases; individual defence; only 5% of marks are collective; peer assessment
Technocratic bias	Consulting tools crowd out legitimacy, distribution and politics	Reality tests; Moore's triangle; distributional rows in templates
Ethical risk in primary research	Harm to respondents; reputational damage	Removed: no primary research (Decision 5)
Thin qualitative evidence	Without fieldwork, some cases have little evidence of how people experience the problem	Case Approval Form requires one published qualitative or field-based source; social audit reports, CAG findings, committee testimony and field studies taught on Day 13
Fabricated evidence from AI tools	False statistics or citations in submissions	AI-use policy; verification status recorded in the evidence register; spot checks at gates
Misattribution and intellectual property	Embarrassment or legal exposure if materials are sold	Attribution categories; redrawn diagrams; advice before commercial launch
Political sensitivity	Participants or the programme drawn into controversy	Working norms in Section 10.5
Overpromising	Participants expect a consulting career from a four-week course	Calibrated promise in Section 1; careful certificate wording

Risk	Consequence	Mitigation
Short duration	Some depth is unavoidably lost, especially in research	Scoped cases; secondary data; an honest limitations section in every report

15. Assumptions requiring confirmation

#	Assumption	Working value	Why it matters	Confirm by
1	Audience	Final-year UG, PG and early-career professionals	Sets the pitch of every session and the level of the outcomes	Decided provisionally (DL-015)
2	Cohort size	12 to 16	Feedback load; Day 20 arithmetic; number of pods	Before Stage 4
3	Teaching team	One instructor, plus at least one guest panellist on Day 20	Feedback capacity; credibility of the panel	Before Stage 4
4	Delivery mode	Not yet known	Design of every activity	Before Stage 7
5	Language	English	Materials, readings and data	Before Stage 6
6	Software	Free tools (Google Docs, Sheets and Slides), so that no participant is excluded by licence cost	Template and workbook formats	Before Stage 6
7	Independent work	About 45 minutes on most days	Workload; scope of each workbook	Before Stage 5
8	Pre-course week	Exists, with diagnostic, case shortlist and primer	Timing of case approval	Before Stage 5
9	Primary research	None; published and public evidence only	Ethics; design of Week 3	Decided (DL-019)
10	Credential	Certificate of completion, with distinction	What the assessment must certify	Deferred to Stage 8 (DL-018)
11	Skills are under-taught	The premise in Section 2 holds for the target audience	The programme's rationale	Entry diagnostic and pilot
12	Cases are Indian	Any state; any level of government	Content of Days 6 and 11	Confirmed

16. Recommendations

16.1 Fourteen changes

R1. One anchor tool per day. Each teaching day has one anchor tool that participants learn to use independently, at most two supporting tools that are demonstrated, and nothing else. Everything else moves to a reference library. This cuts the taught load from about seventy named frameworks and methods to about nineteen anchors and twenty supporting tools, which matches the original aim of teaching fifteen to twenty in depth.

R2. Move the working hypothesis to Day 3. Introduce the hypothesis-led tree alongside the issue tree and have participants seal a working answer. Day 9 then becomes the day hypotheses are sharpened into a testable register, not the day they first appear.

R3. Prioritise issues with issue tools and options with options tools. Day 8 should prune the issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, the approach Conn and McLean describe, supported by Pareto reasoning. ICE and the impact-effort matrix rank interventions and belong in Week 4.

R4. Require a client and a decision. Add the named decision-maker and the decision to the Case Approval Form, and make them the first line of every gate submission.

R5. Start case selection before Day 1. A pre-course shortlist, provisional approval on Day 2 and a scope lock on Day 5.

R6. Teach the three reality tests. Give Day 6 to jurisdiction, money and the delivery chain, and keep PESTLE as a completeness check on the issue tree rather than a stand-alone analysis.

R7. Demote SWOT. SWOT describes an organisation, and most participants' problems are not about a single organisation. Keep it in the reference library for cases where the client is an organisation assessing its own capacity.

R8. Replace full cost-benefit analysis with cost-per-outcome reasoning. A participant cannot carry out a credible cost-benefit analysis in one session without data. They can estimate a rough cost per unit of outcome, state their assumptions and test how sensitive the ranking of options is to them. Full cost-benefit analysis becomes a reference tool with a worked example.

R9. Use Moore's strategic triangle as the final test. Every recommended option is tested for public value, for legitimacy and support, and for operational capacity. It sits alongside the desirability, feasibility and viability lens, which comes from product design and pays less attention to legitimacy.

R10. Pair the Strategy Palette with problem-driven iterative adaptation on Day 18. Whether to plan a programme in full or build it through iteration is the point where BCG's adaptive approach and the PDIA literature meet. That is a better use of the Palette than general prioritisation on Day 8.

R11. Develop the spine case before teaching begins. One fully worked case, used in every demonstration.

R12. Fix the workbook numbering. The current draft numbers nineteen daily workbook exercises while also proposing ten integrated workbooks. Adopt ten workbooks aligned to the gates, each containing numbered daily worksheets (for example, Worksheet 3.2), and never number workbooks by day.

R13. Restructure the assessment components as in Section 11, and adopt formative gates with a summative portfolio.

R14. Cap the first cohort at sixteen for a single instructor, and fix the Day 20 format before the cohort size is advertised.

16.2 Proposed revised architecture

This is offered for decision in principle. The full day-by-day curriculum is a Stage 4 deliverable.

Day	Theme	Anchor tool	Supporting (demonstrated)	Theory link	Participant output	Step
1	Problems, clients and decisions	Sorting problems, symptoms, causes and solutions	Seven steps and eightfold path compared	Rittel and Webber	Candidate cases sorted; decision-maker named	1
2	Defining the problem	Problem Definition Canvas	5W1H; precision test	Sen	Problem statement; Case Approval Form	1
3	Structuring	Issue tree (MECE)	Hypothesis-led tree; sealed working answer		Issue tree; sealed answer	2
4	Causes. *Thursday challenge: Root Cause Investigation*	Problem tree	Five Whys; fishbone		Causal diagnosis	2

Day	Theme	Anchor tool	Supporting (demonstrated)	Theory link	Participant output	Step
5	Systems and scope lock. *Gate 1*	Causal loop diagram	Unintended consequences check	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock	Problem diagnostic	2
6	Jurisdiction, money and delivery	Delivery chain map	Seventh Schedule; budget reading; PESTLE as completeness check	Pritchett; Kapur	Delivery chain and funding map	2
7	Actors and political economy	Power-interest map with absent voices	Incentive analysis	Ostrom; Lipsky	Stakeholder and incentive matrix	2
8	Prioritising issues	Pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence	Pareto reasoning	Simon	Pruned tree with rationale	3
9	Hypotheses. *Thursday challenge: Hypothesis Battle*	Hypothesis register	Assumption mapping; competing explanations		Register with disconfirming evidence	3
10	Workplan. *Gate 2*	Workplan matrix: hypothesis, analysis, source, deadline	Evidence gap analysis		Research plan; evidence register opened	4
11	Finding and judging evidence. *Studio*	Source reliability assessment	The Indian data ecosystem		Evidence register entries	5
12	Quantitative analysis. *Studio*	Disaggregation and comparison in a spreadsheet	Chart choice; correlation and causation		Three charts with interpretation	5
13	Qualitative and comparative evidence. *Studio*	Comparative case matrix	Reading published qualitative evidence: audit findings, social audits, testimony, field studies		Comparative matrix; thematic notes	5
14	Testing. *Thursday challenge: Red Team*	Hypothesis testing matrix	Claim, evidence, warrant		Verdict on each hypothesis	5 and 6
15	Synthesis. *Gate 3*	Pyramid Principle with SCQA	Executive summary	Rumelt	Two-page diagnostic memo	6
16	Generating options	How Might We questions with a journey map	Desirability, feasibility, viability; quick impact-effort screen	Hall	At least three distinct options	7
17	Choosing	Options appraisal matrix with a distributional row	Cost per outcome; strategic triangle	Lindblom; Moore; Flyvbjerg	Appraisal and recommendation	7
18	Delivery design	Theory of change	RAPID or RACI; Strategy Palette with PDIA; risk register	Weiss; Lipsky	Implementation plan	7
19	Measurement and pitch. *Thursday challenge: Five-Slide Challenge; Gate 4*	Indicator framework, from inputs to outcomes	Policy windows	Kingdon	Indicator framework; draft deck	7
20	Defence	Panel presentation			Presentation and defence; report due 72 hours later	7

16.3 What moves to the reference library

Porter's Five Forces and the Ansoff Matrix (market frameworks with limited purchase on most public problems), SWOT, ICE scoring (used informally in Week 4), the full logic model (folded into the theory of change), operating model design, full cost-benefit analysis, scenario planning and service blueprinting. Each still gets a tool card, so that participants can use it when their case calls for it.

17. Critical gap audit

This audit assesses the design as it stood before this note.

Dimension	Status	Finding	Action
Intellectual quality	Needs work	Scholars listed but not attached to tasks; risk of name-dropping	Theory placement map (Section 5)
Methodological quality	Needs work	Framework density; hypotheses too late; issues prioritised with intervention tools; one-day cost-benefit analysis unrealistic	R1, R2, R3 and R8
Policy relevance	Gap	No client; no treatment of jurisdiction, fiscal federalism or delivery chains; equity stated but not operationalised	R4, R6 and R9; distributional rows in templates
Pedagogical quality	Needs work	Case approval on Day 5; inconsistent workbook numbering; independent workload not costed; no baseline measure	R5 and R12; Section 9.5; entry diagnostic
Assessment quality	Needs work	One component double-counted; split between group and individual marks undefined; grading load not estimated	R13; Section 9.6
Ethics and integrity	Needs work	No interview protocol; AI-use policy in outline only; no norms for sensitive cases	Section 10.5; protocol and policy drafted in Stage 8
Production quality	Expected gap at this stage	No source register; some attributions in earlier drafts unverified; visual system specified but no template built	Annexes A and B; template built in Stage 9

The sceptical reviewer's questions, answered briefly

Is the course trying to do too much? In its earlier form, yes. With one anchor tool a day it is demanding but achievable.

Is the theory genuinely integrated? Only if each reading produces a workbook question that changes the analysis. The placement map makes this checkable in Stage 4.

Is the practical training demanding enough? Yes, provided the gates are taken seriously and revision is required rather than invited.

Which framework is most likely to be redundant? SWOT, followed by the Ansoff Matrix and Porter's Five Forces.

What has been omitted? Before this note: the client, the reality tests and public finance. Still thin after it: quantitative skills beyond description. That is a deliberate limitation and is stated in the promise.

Would a participant actually get better at solving policy problems? The design gives each participant one complete cycle with feedback at four points, which is more structured practice than most degree programmes provide. Whether it works is an empirical question, and the paired entry and exit diagnostics exist to answer it.

18. Decisions required

18.1 Before Stage 2

These decisions shape the learning outcomes and competency framework directly.

#	Decision	Options	Recommendation	Outcome, 10 November 2026
1	Primary audience	(a) Final-year UG, PG and early-career; (b) PG and professionals only; (c) open entry	(a), with the entry diagnostic used to place participants	Left to the designer. (a) adopted provisionally
2	Anchor-tool rule and revised architecture	Accept in principle; accept with changes; reject	Accept in principle; finalise in Stage 4	Undecided. Adopted provisionally; review when the full curriculum is presented in Stage 4
3	Named client and decision for every case	Required; encouraged; not used	Required	Undecided. Adopted provisionally; the client is a named role, and participants never contact the office
4	Completion standard	Attendance only; Working level in all domains; graded certificate	Working level in all domains, with distinction at the Advanced level in at least six domains	Deferred to Stage 8
5	Primary research	None; optional expert interviews; required interviews	Optional expert interviews only	No primary research. Published and public evidence only
6	Capstone format	As in Section 12; report due on Day 20; presentation only	As in Section 12	Approved

18.2 Before Stages 4 to 7

#	Decision	Recommendation
7	Cohort size	12 to 16 for the first run
8	Delivery mode	Decide before activity design. In person suits simulations; online widens reach
9	Teaching team and Day 20 panel	One instructor plus two guest panellists with policy or consulting experience
10	Pod composition	Same state or city, different problems
11	Spine case	Choose between waste segregation and foundational literacy, or propose another
12	Gate mechanics	Formative gates and a summative portfolio
13	Software	Free tools, with templates also supplied in Microsoft Office formats
14	Pre-course week	Include it

Decisions 1 to 6 were recorded on 10 November 2026, and Stage 2 has begun in `02-learning-outcomes-and-competencies.md`.

Annex A. Initial source register

Status key. **Checked**: bibliographic details confirmed against a publisher, catalogue or the organisation's own site on 10 November 2026. **To verify**: cited from prior knowledge; confirm against the title page or original before the source appears in any teaching material.

Source (Chicago bibliography style)	Used for	Status
Andrews, Matt, Lant Pritchett, and Michael Woolcock. *Building State Capability: Evidence, Analysis, Action*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017.	PDIA; capability traps	To verify
Bardach, Eugene, and Eric M. Patashnik. *A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis: The Eightfold Path to More Effective Problem Solving*. 6th ed. Thousand Oaks, CA: CQ Press, 2019.	Eightfold path	Checked. Publisher lists 2019; some catalogues give 2020. A 7th edition (2024) is reported; decide which edition to teach from
Brown, Tim. "Design Thinking." *Harvard Business Review* 86, no. 6 (2008): 84-92.	Human-centred design	To verify
Colby, Susan, Nan Stone, and Paul Carttar. "Zeroing In on Impact." *Stanford Social Innovation Review*, 2004.	Intended impact and theory of change	Checked (authors, title, year via Bridgespan); issue details to verify
Conn, Charles, and Robert McLean. *Bulletproof Problem Solving: The One Skill That Changes Everything*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley, 2018.	Seven-step process; pruning the tree	Checked against secondary listings; confirm year on title page
Deloitte. "Government Enterprise Transformation." Deloitte United States. Accessed November 10, 2026. https://www.deloitte.com/us/en/industries/government-public/about/government-enterprise-transformation.html.	Five-stage transformation sequence	Checked (stage names only)
Flyvbjerg, Bent, and Dan Gardner. *How Big Things Get Done*. New York: Currency, 2023.	Optimism bias; reference-class forecasting	To verify
Fritz, Verena, Kai Kaiser, and Brian Levy. *Problem-Driven Governance and Political Economy Analysis: Good Practice Framework*. Washington, DC: World Bank, 2009.	Political economy analysis	To verify
Hall, Peter A. "Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State: The Case of Economic Policymaking in Britain." *Comparative Politics* 25, no. 3 (1993): 275-96.	Orders of change	To verify
HM Treasury. *The Green Book: Central Government Guidance on Appraisal and Evaluation*. London: HM Treasury, 2022.	Options appraisal; Five Case Model	To verify current edition
Kapur, Devesh. "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 34, no. 1 (2020): 31-54. https://doi.org/10.1257/jep.34.1.31.	Indian state capacity	Checked
Kingdon, John W. *Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies*. Boston: Little, Brown, 1984.	Multiple streams	To verify; consider the later updated edition
Lindblom, Charles E. "The Science of 'Muddling Through.'" *Public Administration Review* 19, no. 2 (1959): 79-88.	Incrementalism	To verify
Lipsky, Michael. *Street-Level Bureaucracy: Dilemmas of the Individual in Public Services*. New York: Russell Sage Foundation, 1980.	Frontline discretion	To verify; an expanded edition exists

Source (Chicago bibliography style)	Used for	Status
Mangla, Akshay. *Making Bureaucracy Work: Norms, Education and Public Service Delivery in Rural India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022.	Bureaucratic norms in Indian service delivery	To verify
Minto, Barbara. *The Pyramid Principle: Logic in Writing and Thinking*. London: Pearson.	Pyramid Principle; SCQA	Edition and year to confirm
Moore, Mark H. *Creating Public Value: Strategic Management in Government*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1995.	Strategic triangle	To verify
Muralidharan, Karthik. *Accelerating India's Development: A State-Led Roadmap for Effective Governance*. Gurugram: Penguin Viking, 2024.	Indian state capacity	Checked (publisher and year); place of publication to confirm
Ostrom, Elinor. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990.	Institutions; collective action	To verify
Pritchett, Lant. "Is India a Flailing State? Detours on the Four Lane Highway to Modernization." HKS Faculty Research Working Paper RWP09-013. Cambridge, MA: Harvard Kennedy School, 2009.	Flailing state	To verify
Reeves, Martin, Knut Haanæs, and Janmejaya Sinha. *Your Strategy Needs a Strategy: How to Choose and Execute the Right Approach*. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2015.	Strategy Palette	To verify
Rittel, Horst W. J., and Melvin M. Webber. "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning." *Policy Sciences* 4, no. 2 (1973): 155-69.	Wicked problems	To verify
Rogers, Paul, and Marcia Blenko. "Who Has the D? How Clear Decision Roles Enhance Organizational Performance." *Harvard Business Review* 84, no. 1 (2006).	RAPID	To verify
Rumelt, Richard P. *Good Strategy/Bad Strategy: The Difference and Why It Matters*. New York: Crown Business, 2011.	Kernel of strategy	To verify
Sen, Amartya. *Development as Freedom*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999.	Capabilities	To verify
Simon, Herbert A. *Administrative Behavior*. New York: Macmillan, 1947.	Bounded rationality	To verify
The Bridgespan Group. "Intended Impact and Theory of Change." December 2020. https://www.bridgespan.org/insights/intended-impact-and-theory-of-change.	Intended impact and theory of change	Checked
Weiss, Carol H. "Nothing as Practical as Good Theory: Exploring Theory-Based Evaluation for Comprehensive Community Initiatives for Children and Families." In *New Approaches to Evaluating Community Initiatives*, edited by James P. Connell, Anne C. Kubisch, Lisbeth B. Schorr, and Carol H. Weiss. Washington, DC: Aspen Institute, 1995.	Theory of change	To verify

Annex B. Items requiring verification

Claims carried over from earlier drafts, or made in this note, that must be checked before they appear in teaching material.

1. The exact wording of the seven steps in Conn and McLean, and whether "prune the tree" uses size of impact and ability to influence as its two axes. Secondary summaries agree; the book itself has not been checked.

2. The CDC "Policy Analytical Framework" named in an earlier draft. Not yet checked.
3. The UK government "Evaluation Resources 2025" named in an earlier draft, and the current edition of the Magenta Book.
4. Bain's statement that RAPID is a registered trademark, and its status in India.
5. The origin of How Might We questions, which secondary accounts trace to Procter & Gamble before IDEO.
6. The origin of SWOT, which is contested and should not be attributed to a single author.
7. The current round, reference year and level of representativeness of every Indian dataset listed in Section 10.3, including the status of the next census.
8. Sources for delivery chain analysis.
9. A possible PwC lead: capabilities-driven strategy, associated with Strategy&. Unverified; for Stage 3.
10. The current form of the Policy Analysis Exercise at the Harvard Kennedy School, cited in Section 13 as a comparison.
11. Which edition of Bardach and Patashnik to teach from, given a reported 2024 edition.